



The video record settings in the 'General Settings' dialog box have tabs and sub-tabs for finer record settings

Features And Performance

ChrisTV probably has almost all the features you'd look for in a PVR software. It has the time-shift feature by which you can pause a telecast, forward through ads, and create your own TV replay. This feature has three modes of operation: software DV encoder, software MPEG encoder and hardware MPEG encoder. (The time-shift feature works only with Windows XP, Windows Media Center Edition or higher.)

Recordings can be stored as MPEG, AVI, XviD, and more; recording is supported with many codecs to choose from. The channel preview and the recorded video quality are satisfactory, whereas the snapshots (which can be taken in the JPEG and BMP formats) give remarkably better results.

Another prominent feature is the scheduler. ChrisTV allows a user to schedule recordings for the entire week. Just select the day of the week and set a timed recording for that day—it's that easy!

Link: www.chris-tv.com

How We Tested

The broad parameters considered for testing Personal Video Recorder software were ease of use, features and performance. Our purpose here is to identify and recommend one software that will serve your requirements on all counts.

Our Test Machine: We tested the PVR software on a Pentium IV 3.4 GHz dual-core CPU with 1 GB of DDR 2 RAM and a LifeView FlyTV Prime 30 TV-Tuner card. A VCD player connected to the Composite input of the TV-Tuner card served as the input signal for testing purposes.

The Test: Software should be easy to use and configure. Keeping this in mind, we looked for a clean interface and easy-to-use methods for configuring and setting up the software.

Apart from the standard features, we also looked for the ability to zoom in while watching TV, pause, and tile displays (showing more than one channel on a single screen). Such features earned a software extra points.

Of course, we didn't want software which had great features and which was really easy to use, while not being able to capture video properly. Therefore, we gave as much weightage to the quality of video capture as to the features and ease of use.

iuVCR

iuVCR features a simple interface, beneath which lies a variety of features and options. This software also features radio tuning (if your tuner card supports it).



The configuration settings of iuVCR are classified under the Video and Audio tabs

Ease Of Use

Installation is, again, wizard-based. The interface design is so sober, it looks like software from the Windows 95 era. The configuration options are classified under the 'Video' and 'Audio' tabs. An 'Info' tab shows the important settings for recording and compression. It also displays other technical information, such as file size and frame rate in fps along with a graph. Overall, the interface may be confusing at first glance, but you'll find it is very organised once you've understood the classification of the settings.

Features And Performance

Basic features include TV channel tuning, TV and video capture, and compression of captured content to various formats including DivX. You may need to install a codec pack on your Windows machine before you can choose from various compression formats for your capture. (We installed K-lite Mega Codec pack.)

Capture/Recording can be controlled by limiting it within a time frame, or by punching in the maximum file size. Moreover, captured files can either be saved in a particular folder in a partition or in different locations across hard disk partitions.

This software offered scheduled and timer recording. With timer recording you can set the software to record for, say, the next one hour; with scheduled recording, you can instruct the software to record from, say, 5 pm to 7 pm for any specific channel or input!

The schedule feature wasn't very impressive, though—it restarted the iuVCR software at the scheduled start time, and it often recorded from the wrong input. Overall, iuVCR is just about OK.

Link: www.iulabs.com/iuvcr/index.shtml

NeoTV

NeoTV needs to be tweaked by the developers; there is plenty of room for improvement in video recording as well as the user interface.

Ease Of Use

When NeoTV is run for the first time at the end of the easy installation process, it requests